

Effective Communication - VitaFit_PRD

Research: Data-backed insights for India

Insight 1: The market is growing fast, so retention is the constraint, not demand.

The India fitness app market reached USD 521 million in 2025 and is projected to hit USD 2.9 billion by 2034, a CAGR of 18.69%. Crucially for product decisions, Android holds a dominant 72.5% share. Paid users are growing too: paid active users rose from about 24 million to 55 million between 2020 and 2025.

Take Away: Acquisition is not the bottleneck. Keeping users is. Build Android-first and optimise for low data usage and mid-range phones.

IMARC Group, India Fitness App Market report (market size, 18.69% CAGR, 72.5% Android share):

<https://www.imarcgroup.com/india-fitness-app-market>

Ken Research, India Digital Fitness & Wellness Platforms report (paid users grew from 24M to 55M):

<https://www.kenresearch.com/industry-reports/india-digital-fitness-wellness-platforms-market>

Insight 2: India has a "knowing-doing gap"

Mintel found 64% of Indians say they don't exercise, and while 46% call a healthy lifestyle their top priority, only 37% actually exercise. The top barrier is time: 31% say they don't have time to exercise. Retention data is even starker. In a Gympik study of over a million respondents across Delhi, Bengaluru, Mumbai and Hyderabad, 53% said they lack the discipline to stay fit, and although 30% had a gym membership, only 11% had been regular for more than six months. Flag that the Gympik study is from 2017, so use it as directional evidence.

Take Away: Indian users want to be fit. They drop off because of motivation and discipline, which is exactly the brief's first problem. Features must create external accountability.

↳ Mintel press release (64% don't exercise, 46% vs 37%, 31% lack time):

<https://www.mintel.com/press-centre/64-of-indians-say-they-dont-exercise/>

↳ Business Standard coverage of the Gympik study (53% lack discipline, only 11% regular after 6 months; from 2017):

https://www.business-standard.com/article/news-ani/53-percent-indians-lack-discipline-to-stay-fit-reveals-gympik-s-research-117082201101_1.html

Insight 3: Indians who do exercise, do it in short bursts.

According to the government's Time Use Survey 2024, about 14% of urban Indians reported exercising, versus 7% in rural areas. Among those who exercised, about 42% did so for 30 minutes or less. A Mumbai focus-group study found lack of time was a barrier mentioned by all groups, with an unstructured schedule cited specifically by women.

Take Away: Short classes (10–20 minutes) must count toward streaks and goals. Squads should be matched by time slot (6 AM, lunch, 9 PM) to fit Indian routines.

↳ IndiaSpend analysis of MoSPI's Time Use Survey 2024 (14% urban vs 7% rural exercise):

<https://www.indiaspend.com/health/9-in-10-indians-do-not-exercise-977727>

↳ Scroll.in charts on the same survey (42% exercise for 30 minutes or less):

<https://scroll.in/article/1090236/in-charts-how-india-doesnt-exercise>

↳ Cambridge University Press, Behaviour Change journal, Mumbai focus-group study (lack of time; unstructured schedules for women):

<https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/behaviour-change/article/recreational-physical-activity-in-urban-india-perceptions-and-a-pilot-intervention/06C8568A85247152D0C0D6BEDFD8B3FA>

Insight 4: Women are the biggest underserved segment, and online fitness solves their barriers.

A Lancet Global Health study found 57% of Indian women were insufficiently active in 2022, compared to 42% of men. The Time Use Survey found only 1 in 25 young women report daily workouts, with social expectations around chores, caregiving and studies pushing fitness down the list. Safety and cultural norms also limit outdoor activity.

Take Away: Home-based, on-demand fitness directly removes the safety and commute barrier. Offer women-only squads and flexible streaks that forgive missed days, since women's schedules are less predictable.

↳ University of Edinburgh summary of the Lancet Global Health study (57% of women vs 42% of men insufficiently active):

<https://www.research.ed.ac.uk/en/clippings/nearly-50-adults-in-india-insufficiently-physically-active-lancet/>

↳ Deccan Chronicle (PTI) coverage of the same study, including the 60% by 2030 projection:

<https://www.deccanchronicle.com/lifestyle/nearly-50-adults-in-india-insufficiently-physically-active-in-2022-lancet-study-901031>

↳ Business Standard on the Time Use Survey gender gap (1 in 25 young women exercise daily):

https://www.business-standard.com/health/indias-gender-fitness-gap-why-fewer-women-exercise-than-men-125091500469_1.html

Insight 5: Language drives connection in India

The IAMAI Kantar Internet in India Report 2024 found 98% of users accessed content in Indic languages, and 57% of urban internet users prefer consuming content in regional languages.

Take Away: This is a strong India-specific angle for the instructor-connection problem. A Hindi, Kannada or Tamil-speaking instructor who knows your name feels far more personal than a generic English video. Instructor Circles should be discoverable by language.

↳ Entrepreneur India coverage of the IAMAI–Kantar Internet in India Report 2024 (98% access Indic content, 57% of urban users prefer regional languages):

<https://india.entrepreneur.com/news-and-trends/internet-users-in-india-set-to-cross-900-mn-led-by-indic/485634>

↳ The Week (PTI) coverage of the same report:

<https://www.theweek.in/wire-updates/business/2025/01/16/dcm51-biz-iamai-internet-usage-report.html>

Insight 6: Indian precedent shows gamification and star instructors work

Cult.fit is your best domestic case study. Its most crucial innovation has been an energy meter that tracks workout intensity and ranks users in real time, and its online classes succeeded because they were built as much as theatre as workout content, with a star cast of seasoned trainers. Its live product also lets members work out with friends and track energy scores. Cite this as validation that the Indian market responds to both levers in your brief.

↳ Performonks analysis of Cult.fit (energy meter gamification, star trainers, online classes as theatre):

<https://performonks.substack.com/p/cultfit-part-i>

↳ Cult.fit on the Apple App Store (cultpass LIVE features and pricing):

Insight 7: Global evidence on community and streaks (no Indian equivalent exists)

Use these briefly as supporting proof. Peloton's app-only subscribers churn at roughly 5.2% a month versus 1.6% for hardware owners, which shows digital-only products need emotional lock-in such as instructor loyalty. Duolingo learners who reach a 7-day streak are 2.4 times more likely to keep using the app. Strava's 2024 report found 58% of respondents made new friends through fitness groups, with making social connections the lead motivator for exercise.

India insights → feature implications (a ready-made slide)

Indian insight	Design implication
Knowing doing gap; only 11% of gym members stay regular past 6 months	Squads create peer accountability
42% of exercisers work out for 30 minutes or less	10–20 min classes count toward streaks
Schedules are unstructured and time-poor	Match squads by time slot; offer a forgiving "streak freeze"
Women are far less active due to safety and chores	Women-only squads; home-first experience
57% of urban users prefer regional language	Instructor Circles filtered by language
72.5% of users are on Android	Android-first, lightweight build
Cult.fit's energy meter and star trainers worked	Leaderboards within a squad only; instructor-led challenges

Recommendation is to combine the strongest ideas into two cohesive features.

Feature 1: VitaFit Squads (motivation → community + gamification). Users join or get matched into a small squad of 5 to 8 people with similar goals and schedules. The squad shares a weekly goal (for example, 15 classes combined), a squad streak that uses a forgiving freeze, and a lightweight feed for high-fives and check-ins. The rationale is that small groups create accountability without the harm of comparing yourself to strangers, and the squad streak borrows Duolingo's proven mechanic. Squad-level quests like "try a new discipline this week" drive the variety behaviour tied to lower churn.

Feature 2: Instructor Circles (instructor connection → community + gamification). Users can follow an instructor and join their "Circle." Each instructor runs a 4-week themed challenge (for example, "30 Days of Flexibility with Priya"), with badges at milestones. Instructors give live shoutouts to Circle members during live classes and send weekly short video or voice notes. Completing the challenge unlocks a small-group live session with the instructor. This turns a one-way video into a relationship, recreating Peloton's instructor loyalty for an app-only product.

The two features also reinforce each other: a squad can take on an instructor's challenge together.

Indianised feature touches

These additions make both features feel built for India rather than copied from the US. For **Squads**, add WhatsApp sharing of squad progress cards (Indians already coordinate everything there), time-slot matching, and women-only squad options. For **Instructor Circles**, add regional-language instructors, and festival-themed challenges tied to the Indian calendar, such as a Navratri garba-zumba challenge, a Diwali "21-day glow-up," and a flagship International Yoga Day challenge on 21 June. Festival challenges also give you natural re-engagement moments across the year.

- ↳ Duolingo blog (7-day streak users 2.4x more likely to continue): <https://blog.duolingo.com/improving-the-streak>
- ↳ Duolingo blog on streak freeze and the Penn/UCLA "slack" research: <https://blog.duolingo.com/how-duolingo-streak-builds-habit>
- ↳ Propel teardown of Peloton retention (digital-only 5.2% vs hardware 1.6% monthly churn; instructor loyalty): <https://www.trypropel.ai/resources/blogs/peloton-retention-strategy-teardown>
- ↳ Peloton Q2 FY2025 shareholder letter (60% lower churn with two or more disciplines): <https://investor.onepeloton.com/static-files/9404c038-4c2e-4652-8069-c6b5cd393b46>
- ↳ Strava press release, Year in Sport 2024 (58% made friends via fitness groups): <https://press.strava.com/articles/strava-releases-annual-year-in-sport-trend>
- ↳ ScienceDirect, "Kudos make you run!" study on Strava clubs (social support increases activity): <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0378873322000909>

Global retention benchmark (for the 3–4% Day-30 figure)

- ↳ Fitness Refined, citing Business of Apps (3% Day-30 retention): <https://fitnessrefined.co/fitness-app-retention-statistics/>
- ↳ Sahha (70% discontinue within 100 days; top apps reach 25%): <https://sahha.ai/blog/health-app-churn-retention/>

Caveats to note:

A few points worth stating up front, India-specific app retention benchmarks aren't publicly available, so paired the global 3–4% Day-30 figure with the Glympik 11% regularity stat as an Indian proxy. The market-size numbers come from research firms and vary between sources. The Cult.fit points come from analyst commentary, not company disclosures.

VitaFit Together: PRD

Project title - VitaFit Together

VitaFit Together is a two-feature initiative that turns solo, on-demand workouts into a shared habit. Its goal is to lift Day-30 retention from an assumed 8% to 12% within two quarters of launch, for users in India.

Description

We are proposing two connected features. Each one tackles one root cause of churn, and both use community and gamification.

Feature	What it is	Root cause it fixes
Squads	Small groups of 5–8 users matched by goal, time slot and language. They share a weekly class target, a forgiving squad streak and a light feed for high-fives.	Drop in user motivation
Instructor Circles	Users follow an instructor and join their Circle. Each instructor runs a 4-week themed challenge with milestone badges, live shoutouts and weekly voice notes. Finishing unlocks a small-group live session.	Lack of personal connection with instructors

The features reinforce each other: a Squad can take on an instructor's challenge together, so peers and instructor both pull the user back.

Problem

VitaFit users stop coming back after the first few weeks, and repeat usage is falling. Two root causes drive this.

1. **Drop in motivation.** Users work out alone, see little visible progress and face no consequence for skipping. Once early enthusiasm fades, nothing pulls them back.
2. **No personal connection with instructors.** On-demand video is one-way. The instructor does not know the user exists, so there is no relationship and no reason to return to a specific person.

Problem statement: Indian users who want to be fit join VitaFit, but without accountability or a human connection they drift away within weeks. This caps lifetime value and forces us to keep paying to re-acquire users.

Why: evidence this is a real problem

External data from India and global benchmarks show the same pattern: people intend to exercise, but motivation and discipline fade fast. Internal figures marked "assumed" are hypotheses to validate with VitaFit analytics.

Market and retention signals

Signal	Data	Source
Demand is strong	India fitness app market was USD 521M in 2025, growing at 18.69% CAGR; Android holds 72.5% share	IMARC Group
Retention is the bottleneck	Health and fitness apps retain about 3% of users at Day 30	Fitness Refined, citing Business of Apps
Indian users drop off	Of gym members surveyed across 4 metros, only 11% stayed regular beyond six months; 53% said they lack discipline (2017 study)	Gympik via Business Standard
Knowing–doing gap	46% call a healthy lifestyle their top priority, but only 37% exercise; 31% cite lack of time	Mintel

User behaviour signals

Signal	Data	Source
Workouts are short	42% of Indians who exercise do so for 30 minutes or less	Scroll.in, Time Use Survey 2024
Schedules are unstructured	Lack of time was cited by every focus group in Mumbai; women cited unstructured schedules	Cambridge, Behaviour Change
Women are underserved	57% of Indian women are insufficiently active vs 42% of men	Lancet Global Health, via Univ. of Edinburgh
Language builds connection	57% of urban internet users prefer regional-language content	IAMAI–Kantar, via Entrepreneur India

Proof the solution levers work

Lever	Data	Source
Streaks	Duolingo users on a 7-day streak are 2.4x more likely to return the next day	Duolingo blog
Instructor loyalty	Peloton app-only users churn at ~5.2%/month vs 1.6% for hardware owners, so digital products need emotional lock-in	Propel teardown
Variety	Peloton churn is ~60% lower for members using 2+ disciplines a month	Peloton Q2 FY25 letter
Community	58% of Strava survey respondents made friends through fitness groups	Strava
Indian precedent	Cult.fit built stickiness with a real-time energy meter and star trainers	Performonks

Assumed internal signals (to validate)

- About 60% of churned users attended fewer than 3 classes in their first 14 days.
- Fewer than 15% of users ever take a second class with the same instructor.
- Users who complete 2+ classes in week 1 retain about 2x better at Day 30.

Success: how we know we've solved it

We've succeeded if users in the test group exercise more often and stay longer, without harming wellbeing. Baselines below are assumed and will be replaced with real data before launch.

North Star metric: Weekly Active Exercisers (WAE), meaning users who complete 2 or more classes in a week.

Primary metrics

Metric	Definition	Baseline (assumed)	Target (test vs control)
Day-30 retention	% of new users active on Day 30	8%	12%
Session frequency	Classes per active user per week	1.4	2
Repeat user %	% of users with 4+ active weeks in first 8 weeks	18%	25%

Feature metrics

Feature	Metric	Target
Squads	% of new users who join a Squad in week 1	35%
Squads	% of Squads hitting their weekly goal	50%
Squads	Squad streak of 4+ weeks	30% of Squads
Instructor Circles	% of users who join at least one Circle	30%
Instructor Circles	Challenge completion rate	25%
Instructor Circles	Repeat classes with the same instructor	+40% vs control
Both	Users trying 2+ disciplines a month	+20% vs control

Guardrail metrics

- Notification opt-out rate does not rise by more than 2 points.
- Squad leave or report rate stays below 5%.
- App rating and NPS do not drop.
- Instructor time spent on Circles stays within 2 hours a week.

Audience: who we're building for

The primary audience is urban Indian working professionals aged 22–40 in their first 60 days on VitaFit. This is where churn is steepest and habits are still forming. Women working out from home are a priority sub-segment.

Segment	Who they are	Core need	Why they matter
Primary: time-poor professionals	22–40, metro and Tier-1 cities, desk jobs, mostly Android	Short workouts that fit around work, and someone to keep them on track	Largest paying base; highest early churn
Priority sub-segment: women at home	25–45, working or homemakers, exercise at home	Safe, flexible, judgement-free workouts; women-only spaces	57% insufficiently active; online removes safety and commute barriers
Secondary: Gen Z	18–24, students and early-career	Social belonging and something to share	Drawn to community fitness; strong word-of-mouth

Personas

Ashwini (36, Scrum Master Bengaluru). She signed up in January, did 6 classes in two weeks, then work got busy. She wants to be fit but has no one checking on her. She prefers 20-minute yoga at 6:30 AM and would enjoy a Kannada-speaking instructor.

Nishant (32, sales executive, Bangalore). He does 3 zumba classes a week but feels like he's working out with a TV. He doesn't know other users and the instructor doesn't know him. He's drifting towards a local gym for the social vibe.

Nairmaliya (20, college student, Bangalore). She's motivated by friends and shareable wins. She will join a challenge if her friends do and post her badge to Instagram and WhatsApp.

What: how it looks in the product

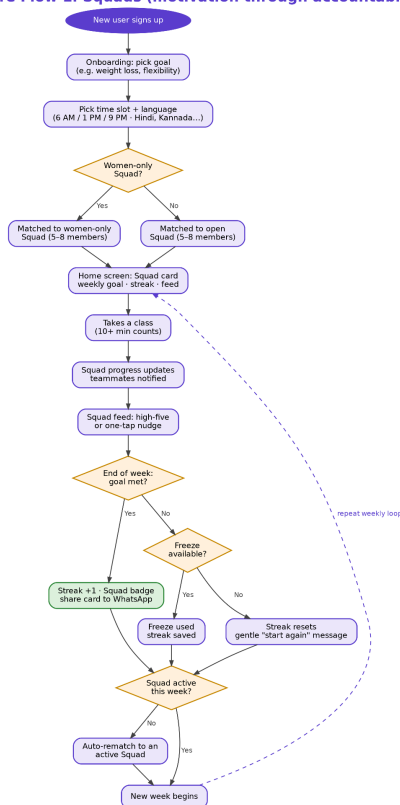
Both features live in a new **Together** tab on the bottom navigation, beside Home, Classes and Profile. They also appear at three key moments: onboarding, the post-class screen and the home screen.

Feature 1: Squads

Users pick a goal, preferred time slot and language during onboarding, then get matched into a Squad of 5–8 people. Everything the Squad does is visible on one Squad card.

Flowchart

Core Flow 1: Squads (motivation through accountability)



The core loop: each class a member finishes adds to the shared weekly goal, and teammates can cheer or nudge each other.

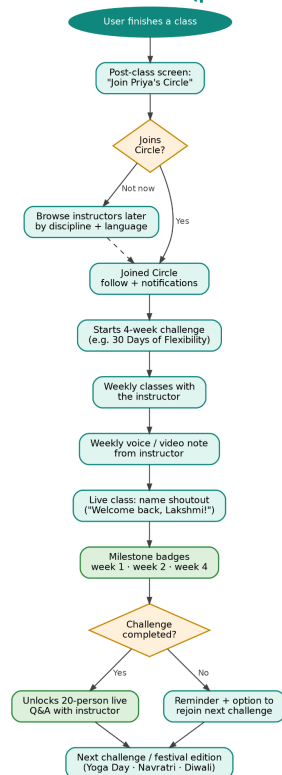
Must	Auto-match into a Squad of 5-8 by goal, time slot (e.g. 6 AM, 1 PM, 9 PM) and language
Must	Shared weekly class goal with a progress bar
Must	Squad streak with 1 freeze per week; classes of 10+ minutes count
Must	Squad feed with high-fives and one-tap nudges
Must	Women-only Squad option
Should	Weekly Squad quest, e.g. "everyone tries a new discipline"
Should	Share Squad progress card to WhatsApp and Instagram
Should	Auto-rematch if a Squad is inactive for 7 days
Could	Invite friends to create a private Squad
Won't (v1)	Global public leaderboards

Feature 2: Instructor Circles

Users can follow an instructor from any class or profile and join their Circle. Each instructor runs a 4-week themed challenge, with festival editions across the year.

Flowchart

Core Flow 2: Instructor Circles (personal connection)



The relationship builds over four weeks, from following to being known by name.

Priority	Requirement
Must	Follow an instructor and join their Circle from the post-class screen
Must	Browse instructors by discipline and language (Hindi, English, Kannada, Tamil, Telugu at launch)
Must	4-week challenge with badges at weeks 1, 2 and 4
Must	Instructor dashboard showing Circle members in live classes, for name shoutouts
Should	Weekly 30–60 second voice or video note from the instructor to the Circle
Should	Challenge completers unlock a 20-person live Q&A class
Should	Festival challenges: International Yoga Day (21 June), Navratri garba-zumba, Diwali 21-day challenge
Could	Squad takes a Circle challenge together
Won't (v1)	Paid 1:1 instructor sessions

Where it appears in the app

- **Onboarding:** a Squad match step after goal selection.
- **Post-class screen:** "Join Priya's Circle" and Squad progress update.
- **Home screen:** Squad card and active challenge card at the top.
- **Notifications:** capped at 1 a day, sent in the user's time slot.

How: experiment plan

We will ship a lean MVP of each feature, test them separately and together in an A/B test on new users, then scale what works.

Hypotheses

- **H1 (Squads):** If new users join a Squad with a shared goal and streak, Day-30 retention will rise by at least 3 points, because peer accountability replaces fading motivation.
- **H2 (Instructor Circles):** If users join an instructor's Circle and challenge, repeat classes with that instructor will rise by 40%, because a personal relationship gives them a reason to return.

Test design

New Android and iOS users in Bengaluru, Mumbai, Delhi NCR, Pune and Hyderabad are randomly split into four groups for 8 weeks.

Group	Gets	Share of new users
Control	Current app	25%
A	Squads only	25%
B	Instructor Circles only	25%
C	Squads + Instructor Circles	25%

This tells us each feature's standalone impact and whether they work better together. We need about 4,000 users per group to detect a 3-point Day-30 lift; the exact size will be confirmed with our data team.

Phased rollout

Phase	Scope	Exit criteria
0. Validate	15 user interviews; clickable prototype tests; confirm internal baselines	Users understand both features; baselines confirmed
1. MVP beta	500 opt-in users; Squads with goal, streak and feed; 5 instructors with one challenge each	No major usability issues; Squad weekly-goal rate above 40%
2. A/B test	4-group test on new users in 5 cities for 8 weeks	Primary metrics hit targets; guardrails hold
3. Scale	Winning variant to 100% of users; add Should-have requirements and festival challenges	Day-30 retention lift holds for 2 more cohorts

MVP scope (Phase 1)

- **Squads:** auto-match, weekly goal, squad streak with freeze, high-fives and nudges.
- **Instructor Circles:** follow, join Circle, one 4-week challenge with badges, live shoutouts.
- **Deferred:** voice notes, WhatsApp sharing, festival challenges and private friend Squads.

When: timeline and milestones

The MVP beta ships in week 10 and the A/B test reads out in week 20, about five months from kickoff. Timelines assume one squad of 2 mobile engineers, 1 backend engineer, 1 designer and 1 PM.

Weeks	Milestone	Output
1–2	Discovery	15 user interviews, baseline data pull, instructor feedback sessions
3–4	Wireframes	Core flows for Squads and Instructor Circles
5–6	Prototype and usability tests	Clickable prototype tested with 10 users; design finalised
7–10	MVP build	Squads and Circles MVP; instructor dashboard; analytics events
10–11	Beta	500 opt-in users; 5 instructors onboarded
12–20	A/B test	4-group test across 5 cities for 8 weeks
20–21	Readout and decision	Results review; go or no-go to scale
22+	Scale	Full rollout; festival challenges timed to Navratri and Diwali

Risks and mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Squads go quiet and demotivate members	Auto-rematch after 7 days of inactivity; seed Squads with at least 2 active users
Social comparison hurts wellbeing, especially for women	No global leaderboards; progress shown at Squad level; private stats by default
Instructors lack time for Circles	Templated voice notes; shoutouts powered by a live-class dashboard; cap at 2 hours a week
Streak pressure leads to burnout	Weekly freeze; 10-minute classes count; no penalties for missed days
Too many notifications	Cap at 1 a day, sent in the user's chosen time slot
Harassment in Squad feeds	Reactions and preset messages only in v1; report and block tools

Open questions

- What are VitaFit's real Day-30 retention and classes-per-week baselines?
- How many instructors can commit to running a Circle at launch?
- Should Squads be open to free users or only paid subscribers?

Sources

- [IMARC Group: India Fitness App Market](#)
- [Fitness Refined: Fitness App Retention Statistics 2026](#)
- [Business Standard: Gympik study](#)
- [Intel: 64% of Indians say they don't exercise](#)
- [Scroll.in: How India doesn't exercise](#)
- [IndiaSpend: 9 in 10 Indians do not exercise](#)
- [Cambridge, Behaviour Change: Recreational physical activity in urban India](#)
- [University of Edinburgh: Lancet Global Health study summary](#)
- [Business Standard: India's gender fitness gap](#)

